

A summary of input, not a decision

What was raised, and by whom.

This page summarises input from the Camden Future Food Dinner, the Future Food System Workshop on 6 August, and the research sessions that preceded them. It has not been agreed by the Partnership. Ideas are organised against the three foundations of the Food as Infrastructure portfolio, to identify who is positioned to take each one forward.

[See the foundations](#)

[Open the full portfolio site](#)

Camden Future Food Dinner

Calthorpe Community Garden
— where this conversation
started for many in the room.

Future Food System Workshop

6 August — five tables, one
facilitator reflection, dozens of
ideas.

Research to date

Negative Portfolio v2.0, Hubs &
Markets Working Group,
Nutrition Supply Map, Live Map.

Next deadline

5 Oct 2026 — Cabinet's call for views on the Civil Contingencies Act.

Where this comes from

The Dinner, The Workshop, The Work

Nothing here is new, and none of it is decided. It's a synthesis of what was actually said, pulled together so it reads as one shared memory instead of three separate ones.

The dinner

Camden Future Food Dinner

Held at Calthorpe Community Garden. The first time many partners sat down together around the size of the challenge — and the first outline of Camden as a demand-shaper rather than a producer.

The workshop

Future Food System Workshop

6 August — five parallel table conversations and a closing reflection. Almost every idea below traces back to something said at one of these tables.

The research

Built and published so far

The Negative Portfolio v2.0, the Hubs & Markets Working Group, the Nutrition Supply Map, and the Live Camden food-system map — the evidence base this page sits on top of.

The theory of change hasn't moved

The same three foundations

Everything raised in the room is organised below against the same three foundations the wider Food as Infrastructure portfolio is built on. They're the test every idea on this page eventually has to pass.

Nutrient density is the target, not calories

The baseline shifts from “enough food” to genuinely nourishing food — because a system that only solves for calories quietly manufactures the next public-health crisis while claiming to have solved the last one.

Organic supply grows through collective buying power

No single borough's contract is big enough to move a farmer's decision. A buying coalition of London boroughs and businesses is — turning committed public and commercial demand into the confidence a grower needs to convert land.

Civic-led delivery is what actually brings it to life

Procurement protocols and buying coalitions don't feed anyone on their own. Grocers, dinners, workshops and community-run hubs are the layer where the foundations above turn into food someone can actually buy or receive.

One of the three foundations

Nutrient density is the target, not calories

Ideas raised in the room that shift what Camden measures and pays attention to — from “enough food” to food that actually nourishes people.

● Supply ● Hub ● Demand The wider portfolio's own tracks, tagged for reference

Nutrition & supply-gap mapping

● Supply

Map what Camden residents actually need nutritionally against what's currently grown and available, before committing to new contracts or sponsored farmland.

Grounded in: the regional-sourcing table, Future Food System Workshop — feeds the existing Nutrition Supply Map tool.

Energy in the room: Open — no one at the table claimed this as theirs to drive.

Consumption transparency

● Demand

An annual receipt totalling spend, salt and sugar against delivery-app orders — no verdict attached, just the number, the way cigarette packaging works.

Grounded in: the Indy reflection session, the “£8,000 on Uber Eats” moment.

Energy in the room: A vivid anecdote, not yet a plan. Open.

Marketing Investment Fund

● Demand

A cross-retailer fund investing in demand for healthy food and new food cultures, priced against the revenue uplift it creates — because no public body can out-spend existing food marketing budgets alone.

Grounded in: the Indy reflection session — a named item on the main portfolio site’s Demand track.

Energy in the room: Indy’s own framing; more a research agenda right now than a pick-up-and-run item.

Farmacy pilot

● Hub

Pharmacies reframed as neighbourhood performance-and-nutrition nodes — fresh food, dietary advice and community links, framed around aspiration rather than illness.

Grounded in: the new-economics table — already named and scoped identically on the main portfolio site.

Energy in the room: Indy’s idea — landed hard enough that a business owner in the room (Carl) reacted to it as a live opportunity for his own pivot.

Food training for health practitioners

● Hub

Basic nutrition training and food-prescription routes for GPs and health workers — related to, but distinct from, the Farmacy pilot itself.

Grounded in: the health-link conversation, Future Food System Workshop.

Energy in the room: Raised, not yet claimed. Open.

Default-healthy public catering

● Demand

Collapse the choice down to healthy options only, rather than removing choice altogether — the simplification that makes a genuinely robust supply chain possible behind it.

Grounded in: a separate conversation between Dark Matter Labs and Camden’s Health & Wellbeing Department, on school catering.

Energy in the room: Raised by a Camden colleague (Lindsay), refined by Ayanna Griffith into “make every choice healthy” rather than removing choice.

One of the three foundations

Organic supply grows through collective buying power

Ideas raised in the room about turning Camden’s buying power — and Camden alongside other boroughs’ buying power — into the confidence a grower or supplier needs to convert land or change practice.

Sponsored / underwritten farmland

● Supply

Camden-backed relationships with farms outside the borough, scaling proven cooperative wholesale models (e.g. the Better Food Traders network) rather than duplicating them.

Grounded in: the regional-sourcing table — with an open governance question about sponsorship vs. ownership still unresolved.

Energy in the room: Dorothea pushed hardest for this at the table — worth following up with her directly.

Organic-transition bridge financing

● Supply

Support for farms through the multi-year dip in income (“J-curve”) that agroecological conversion typically causes, financed against a long-term buying commitment.

Grounded in: the Future Food Dinner and the Indy reflection session, echoing the Danish 90%-by-2040 procurement model.

Energy in the room: Raised in Indy’s session; no named lead yet.

Automated farm-to-farm coverage

● Supply

A forecasting engine that predicts surplus and shortfall across a network of farms and routes supply between them before a contract breaks.

Grounded in: the Indy reflection session, in the supply-chain conversation with Andy and Carl.

Energy in the room: Carl and Andy were already thinking this through out loud, unprompted — a real signal.

Community water infrastructure

● Supply

Subsidised water butts and sustainable drainage capture linked to growing spaces, treating water access as a limiting factor worth investing in directly.

Grounded in: the regional-sourcing table, referencing NYC precedent.

Energy in the room: A passing idea, written down on the spot. Open.

Collective buying engine

● Hub

Scale the existing “one conversation instead of a hundred” model (Young Foundation / Carl) into a repeatable, institutional capability rather than a personal relationship.

Grounded in: the Indy reflection session — matches the site’s own definition almost word for word.

Energy in the room: Carl’s own business needs this to exist within six months — about as real as energy gets in the room.

Procurement charter

● Demand

A joint public/private Camden charter, deliberately set beyond existing certifications — Food for Life Served Here's gold standard only requires around 15% organic.

Grounded in: the procurement table, both workshops — the direct precursor to the portfolio's Procurement Protocol.

Energy in the room: Rosemary put her name to this directly on the day: “if anyone wants to talk about a charter, let's do it.”

Conditions on scarce, sought-after assets

● Demand

Attaching living-wage and healthy-catering conditions to access that's already in high demand — such as Camden Market/Lock's three-year trader waiting list.

Grounded in: the procurement table — a low-cost move using power the council already has, not new money.

Energy in the room: Raised with a concrete example already in hand — practical enough that it just needs someone to start the conversation.

Incentives & disincentives policy

● Demand

A broader policy ask than the procurement charter alone — shaping what's easy and hard to buy across the borough, not just what the council itself buys.

Grounded in: the table-summaries session, Future Food System Workshop.

Energy in the room: Named as a gap, not yet claimed by anyone.

De-risked transitional ownership

● Supply

A company majority-owned by the council from day one, with private capital covering the up-front cost of in-sourcing a contract — repaid over time until the council holds it outright.

Grounded in: a separate conversation between Dark Matter Labs and Camden's Health & Wellbeing Department — Camden had already explored, and shelved, in-sourcing school catering over up-front cost.

Energy in the room: Not yet tested with Camden's own procurement team — a structure worth taking back to them, not a live commitment.

One of the three foundations

Civic-led delivery is what actually brings it to life

The largest group of ideas from the room — the hubs, co-ops, grocers, matchmaking and organising that turn the two foundations above into food someone can actually buy or receive.

Camden food hub(s)

● Hub

The single biggest tangible near-term idea named at the workshop — a hub-and-spoke model, anchored at Regis Road, with composting/anaerobic digestion planned alongside it.

Grounded in: multiple tables — directly continued by the London Hubs & Markets Working Group.

Energy in the room: Already has a name behind it — Damien Conrad (Felix Project) is directing the Hubs & Markets Working Group carrying this forward.

Co-op toolkit, minimum standards & branding

● Hub

A recognisable, minimum-standards toolkit so anyone can start a co-op and residents can recognise one the way they'd recognise a supermarket or the Underground.

Grounded in: the co-ops table, Future Food System Workshop.

Energy in the room: Strong table consensus; no single name attached yet.

Micro-enterprise & community kitchen routes

● Hub

Referral routes into compliant community kitchens for residents who want to batch-cook or sell food but whose home kitchens aren't set up for it.

Grounded in: the regional-sourcing table, Future Food System Workshop.

Energy in the room: Raised, not yet claimed.

Public-interest grocers & multi-ledger ownership

● Hub

Next-generation, membership-model grocers with genuinely lower prices on a fixed cadence, and part-volunteer/part-paid/part-commercial ownership structures.

Grounded in: the Indy reflection session, riffing on the Mamdani NYC grocery model.

Energy in the room: Indy's own thread; still abstract enough that no one's picked it up locally.

Fresh food access points

● Hub

UK-viable versions of vending-style fresh produce access (the Farmer's Fridge model) for transit and other high-footfall locations.

Grounded in: raised independently at both the action-options and regional-group tables.

Energy in the room: Floated twice, independently — a real signal, but still no owner.

Social value live-matchmaking

● Hub

A real-time mechanism connecting community projects with contractors and developers already on site, so in-kind support isn't lost once a contract ends.

Grounded in: Kira's (Camden social value lead) contribution at the regional-group table.

Energy in the room: Kira is already doing versions of this — the clearest existing energy on this page.

Neighbourhood action groups

● Hub

Local groups covering every area of the borough, deliberately linked to the parallel health neighbourhood networks work.

Grounded in: the table-summaries session, Future Food System Workshop.

Energy in the room: Named as a gap, not yet a plan. Open.

Street food & micro-licensing

● Demand

Formalising licensing for street food and small-scale enterprise — the most carbon- and infrastructure-efficient food format there is.

Grounded in: the new-economics table — matches the site's Street Food Licensing item directly.

Energy in the room: Conceptual for now; no named owner.

School land-sharing for growing & education

● Supply

Pairing schools with spare playing fields against schools that have growing space. The table's own conclusion: safeguarding and DBS constraints mean this lands as an education role, not a supply source — worth stating plainly rather than quietly dropping.

Grounded in: the regional-sourcing table, Future Food System Workshop.

Energy in the room: The table talked itself out of this one in real time — land and safeguarding both cited as genuine blockers.

Civic muscle: organising & accountability

These don't have a Supply/Hub/Demand tag because they're not infrastructure — they're what makes the Partnership itself credible enough to run any of the above.

Precedent

Right to Grow

Already has council officer time behind it — the table's point was that it needs community weight alongside that, not instead of it.

Inside the council

A food champion in every department

The Enfield example: someone from Properties having to work out how food relates to their own remit. No one owns making this happen yet.

Reaching residents

A resident-facing newsletter

Distinct from the existing partner-facing one. Open — raised as a gap, not claimed.

Reaching residents

Piggyback on existing engagement

Came from someone already running the health bus — practical and ready to extend, not hypothetical.

Resilience

A People's Emergency Briefing

Named directly in the closing round; no single lead confirmed yet.

Resilience

A food-activity & risk register

Distinct from the Nutrition Supply Map. A good pairing with whoever picks up the resilience committee below.

Accountability

Bring in elected councillors directly

A challenge thrown to the room, not picked up on the day — worth asking who felt strongly enough to say it.

Who's missing

Non-traditional food actors

Farah is already doing some engagement with convenience stores and small shops — worth checking what would help her do more.

Convening format

The Future Food Dinner

Already run once in Camden; the plan is to scale it into a quarterly convening for food and health leads across London boroughs — the actual mechanism behind Tier 2's coalition, not just its ambition.

Accountability practice

Self-nomination, declared in public

People nominate themselves for a workstream and declare where they want to be in six months, validated by the group — soft accountability that separates real energy from a meeting habit.

A few ideas from the room are being left out deliberately, not by oversight: declaring a national state of emergency, taxing the rich to fund co-ops, and planning food capacity for climate refugees. All were raised as genuine provocations about the scale of the risk — but none are things Camden or the Partnership can pick up and drive right now.

Three horizons, not one deadline

The wider portfolio runs on three speeds at once. Here's what that means for the ideas above.

Now, before 5 Oct 2026

Shock absorption

- Respond to the Cabinet's Civil Contingencies Act call for views
- Stand up a Local Food Resilience Committee, statutory or not
- Start the nutrition & supply-gap mapping
- Open up Food Partnership meetings — low-stakes topics first

Next, 12-18 months

Coalition & charter

- Publish a declared Food Partnership work programme
- Camden and 3-4 peer boroughs align on collective buying
- Camden food hub(s) go live on the hub-and-spoke model
- Procurement charter published; Farmacy pilot scoped and tested

2028 and beyond

The labour shock

- Automation reaches logistics and white-collar work at scale
- Food-as-infrastructure is the argument made *before* that shock, not the response after it
- Co-op branding, collective buying and sponsored farmland mature into the default, not the pilot

Where's the energy?

Not a RACI chart. This is a reading of the room — where someone already showed up with real energy for an idea, named or not, and what's still an open question. The point of the next Partnership conversation is to test these readings out loud, not to confirm them from behind a desk.

Idea	Energy already visible on the day	Open question to ask the room
Resilience committee	Tanya brought the proposal and put her name to it directly	Who convenes it locally and keeps the risk register alive after the first meeting?
Procurement charter	Rosemary: "if anyone wants to talk about a charter, let's do it"	Who else wants in, and who owns the supplier relationships day to day?
Social value live-matchmaking	Kira is already doing versions of this as Camden's social value lead	Does she want this to become a repeatable process, or stay as it is?
Camden food hub(s)	Damien Conrad (Felix Project) is already directing the Hubs & Markets Working Group carrying this forward	Who from Camden sits alongside him on it day to day?
Collective buying engine	Carl's own business needs this to exist within six months	Who helps that urgency become an institutional capability, not just Carl's own relationships?
Sponsored / underwritten farmland	Dorothea pushed hardest for this at the table	Who follows up on the sponsorship-vs-ownership question she raised?
Farmacy pilot	Indy's idea; Carl reacted to it live as an opportunity for his own business pivot	Who scopes an actual pilot site and partner?
Non-traditional food actors	Farah is already doing some of this engagement	What would help her do more of it?
Co-op toolkit & standards	Strong consensus at the table — no single name attached yet	Who's willing to put their name on this first?

London-wide coalition

Camden is already several boroughs ahead via the Hubs & Markets Working Group

Which peer borough lead picks up the phone next?

If any of this is you

Put your name to it

If you recognise your own energy in any row above — or in any card further up this page — say so at the next Partnership meeting, or reply directly so it doesn't sit as an unclaimed idea for another quarter. The job right now is finding out who's genuinely ready to carry something, not assigning it.

Governance tiers, restated

The same three tiers as the wider portfolio

Tier 1: borough

An independent Food Partnership

Camden Council keeps a seat at the table — funding, convening, advertising the work — without holding the steering wheel. A declared, public work programme replaces “come and collaborate.”

Tier 2: London

A coalition of boroughs

Camden and a founding group of neighbouring boroughs take on shared standards and collective buying — the exact agenda the London Hubs & Markets Working Group is already running, several boroughs early.

Tier 3: national

Permission from the centre

A policy briefing, routed through Oxford, arguing for the deregulation that lets capable local actors build without red tape — timed to the Civil Contingencies Act review window.

The concrete first move

Set up a Local Food Resilience Committee — before the law requires it

This is the one action from the workshop that appears almost word for word in the wider portfolio's own “concrete first move” — proposed independently at the table by a Partnership member, and matched exactly by the National Preparedness Commission's review.

Cabinet call for views closes 5 October 2026

Food isn't part of Camden's emergency response yet. That's the gap to close first.

The Borough Resilience Forum already covers police, hospitals, ambulance and fire. Tim Lang's National Preparedness Commission review recommends every local authority add a food resilience committee — the Cabinet Office is deciding whether to make that statutory. A borough that moves first has already done most of the work before the law asks for it.

[Read Tim Lang's report ↗](#)

[Respond before 5 Oct ↗](#)

Held, not resolved

The open tensions worth naming out loud

A few genuine disagreements ran through the room. They're decisions the Partnership needs to make deliberately, not oversights in this synthesis.

Independence vs. council backing

How far the Partnership moves from council control, given even the most dynamic independent food partnerships nationally still rely on council funding and a seat at the table.

Sponsorship vs. ownership of land and farms

Sponsoring farms outside Camden raises the same question as council-sponsored co-ops — how much control follows the money, and who decides.

One big summit vs. distributed workshops

Still unresolved from the workshop itself, and it shapes who's actually reached versus who's easiest to convene.

Standards as inclusion vs. exclusion

Charters, minimum standards and conditions on traders all raise the floor — but can lock out the smallest, least-resourced actors they're partly meant to help.

Near-term pragmatism vs. systemic ambition

Several participants warned against designing only for the next two years, given how fast the underlying economic conditions may move — the portfolio needs items that work now *and* as a Trojan horse toward the longer horizon.

Already live

The research this page stands on

Every idea above sits on top of work that's already built and public. Worth opening before your next Partnership conversation.

Negative Portfolio NP 2.0

The Camden Horizon Navigator

Food fragility treated as a demand-construction opportunity, not a supply deficit.

Pathways

Six Pathways to a Civic Food System

Six distinct levers for moving London's buying power behind organic, resilient, civic-led food — with an honest read on where the portfolio already has traction.

One example pathway

The Camden Plan, Plainly

A plain-English walkthrough of one way to sequence the eight-shelf portfolio, idea to instrument — a worked example, not the definitive route.

Working group

London Hubs & Markets

Where the Hub track gets tested against real boroughs, leases and funding gaps.

Supply map

Nutrition Supply Map

Where Camden's food actually comes from, and the shocks that travel home with it.

Live map

The Camden food system, mapped

Hubs, retailers, growers and routes in one place — with an audio briefing.

Money & policy

A Sovereign Food System

Economic and monetary instruments for redesigning food-system finance, built for Sweden.

Where's the Energy? A summary for the Camden Food Partnership

A Dark Matter Labs research, coordination and funding-orchestration programme. Camden is a partner in this, not a commissioner of it.

Full portfolio site

Hubs & Markets Working Group

Contact Dark Matter Labs ↗

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